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HERDERS-FARMERS CONFLICT, IMPLICATIONS FOR THE SAFETY OF LEARNERS AND MEMBERS OF STAFF IN NIGERIAN SCHOOLS

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Abstract

Herders-Farmers conflict is one of the major security challenges facing Nigeria in recent times, this has claimed lives, displaced people from their original homes, disrupted academic programmes and calendar across Nigerian schools and threatened the entire education system. This study examined how violent conflicts between herders and farmers affect the safety of learners and members of staff in Nigerian schools. The study explored the causes of herders-farmers conflict in Nigeria. Drawing on human security perspectives, the study relied on secondary data from academic literature, policy reports, and documented incidents. The findings of the study revealed that killings, displacement of people from their original homes, abductions, indefinite closure of schools, distortion of school programmes and academic calendar, destruction of critical infrastructure and psychological trauma are recurring outcomes of herders-farmers conflict. The study concluded that insecurity generated as a result of herders-farmers conflict significantly undermines safe school/learning environments. The study recommended that government and relevant stakeholders should strengthen sustainable peace building, improved security architecture, community security, ensure policy reforms on grazing and improve school protection frameworks, tie bonds, build mutual trust and actions such as information sharing. These will mitigate herders-farmers conflict, its security threats and ensure safer society and safer learning environments.

Key words: Herders-farmers conflict, Nigerian schools, Safety of learners and members of staff.

Introduction

Herders-farmers conflict has become one of the major security challenges facing Nigeria in recent times. It has evolved from a resource-based dispute into a major security challenge with severe implications for education especially in the North-Central, Western and Southern regions of the country. Originally based on competition over grazing land, water and grazing routes, the conflict has escalated due to population pressure, climate change, proliferation of small arms, presence of terrorists and cattle rustlers in the forests of the North-East where the herders originally use to pasture their herds of cattle, and weak policies and governance structures. This insecurity extends to schools that are located in conflict affected communities and often exposes learners and staff to threats of insecurity including abduction, displacement, loss of lives and properties, rape and psychological trauma, hence they shut down pending when peace and normalcy returns and in some cases, displaced people tend to move to nearby safer areas with less school facilities, thus not allowing them to access education (Reuters, 2024). Schools which are originally meant to serve as safe environments for the acquisition of knowledge, values, basic tools for national development, human capital formation and social transformation and competencies required for societal progress, has in recent times become vulnerable targets in conflict-prone areas, especially in states such as Adamawa, Bauchi, Benue, Borno, Edo, Kaduna, Katsina, Kogi, Kwara, Nasarawa, Niger, Plateau, Sokoto, Taraba, Yobe, Zamfara, and the Federal Capital Territory FCT-Abuja.

Herder-farmer conflict is primarily associated with competition for scarce resources, grazing routes and human activities. Factors such as population growth, desertification, climate change, ethnic tensions, weak governance structures and proliferation of arms and ammunition have over time, intensified the conflict. It is argued that environmental pressures, scarcity and competition for resources are the major drivers of herders-farmers conflict. According to Obikaeze et al. (2023), struggles between herders and farmers have generated “human and food security challenges” across Nigerian communities. Herders-farmers conflict has become pronounced in almost all the states the country. Beyond the loss of lives and destruction of property, herder-farmer conflict increasingly undermines educational development and school safety.

Following the complexities of security challenges in Nigeria and the implications on host communities of Nigerian schools, there has been an increasing advocacy for practicable and collaborative approaches involving all stakeholders to develop vital strategies for enhancing school/host community safety, promoting peace and strengthening social cohesion. The adoption of peace building and security is perceived to have the capacity to promote a sustainable and contextually responsive approach to combating the rising tension between herders and farmers in school host communities. Strengthening bonds between them, underpinned by mutual trust, shared responsibilities and collaborative actions, can significantly mitigate security threats and foster safer school learning environments in Nigeria. Based on these numerous concerns and drawing on human security perspectives, this study relied on secondary data from academic literature, policy reports, and documented incidents to critically explore the implications of herders-farmers conflict for learners and members of staff in Nigerian schools.

Statement of the Problem

It is fundamental that Nigerian schools function effectively in safe environments especially guaranteeing the safety of the learners and the members of the entire school communities. This seems to be the paramount concern among educational stakeholders such as the Ministry of Education, school authorities, security agencies, parents and host communities due to their pivotal role in ensuring safety of learners and members of staff in schools. However, the study observed that Nigerian Schools may be having issues of insecurity arising from conflicts affecting host communities over farmland-grazing land, water and grazing routes. Observation also indicates that most times, schools get confused and helpless on how to avoid the resultant killings, closure of schools, displacement, psychological trauma and distortion of school programmes and calendar. Inadequate security measures seem to affect the safety of learners and members of staff. Government and some schools seem to fail in their role to provide perimeter fencing, adequately trained security personnel and equipment. All these appear to create chances for insecurity. It is against this backdrop that investigation into herders-farmers conflict, implication for the safety of learners and members of staff in Nigerian schools is being undertaken.

Conceptual Framework

Herders-Farmers Conflict: Herders-Farmers conflict refers to violent clashes between pastoralists herders and sedentary farmers in farming communities over access to grazing land, water and grazing routes. According to Chukwuma (2020). Herders-farmers conflict refers to violent confrontations arising from competition over natural resources between pastoral livestock keepers and sedentary crop farmers. He described the conflict as a major security issue involving questions of “who or what is to be secured, from what threat and by what means”. Similarly, Chiluwa and Chiluwa (2020) noted that herder-farmer conflict has become one of Nigeria’s most significant security concerns attracting local and international attention because of its destructive consequences. When this kind of violent clash occurs, many lives are often lost, houses and other properties are destroyed including farms, inhabitants of the affected community become displaced and either move to designated Internally Displaced Persons (IDP) Camps and or nearby safer communities which may not have educational facilities thereby making it difficult for learners to have access to education.

Nigerian Schools: Nigerian Schools refer to the various educational institutions (public/private) where learners are taught by trained teachers to acquire knowledge, values and competencies required for self-realization, social development and societal progress. They include properly established and equipped nursery, primary, secondary and tertiary institutions such as universities, colleges of education, polytechnics, mono-technics and others within Nigeria.

Safety of Learners and Members of Staff: Safety encompasses the protection of learners and members of staff including teachers and non-teaching staff of schools, from any form of physical harm, psychological trauma, environmental threats and disrupted academic activities, programmes

and calendar. It provides secured learning environments free from violence, fear, intimidation and disruption. According to human security perspective, safety extends beyond physical protection to include freedom from fear, freedom from want and access to essential services such as education.

Theoretical Framework

Human Security Theory emphasizes the protection of individuals rather than merely safeguarding state borders. Human security includes personal security, economic security and educational security. According to the human security perspective, safety extends beyond physical protection to include freedom from fear, freedom from wants and access to essential services such as education. The relevance of this theory lies in its recognition that violent conflicts threaten not only lives but also access to education. When communities experience insecurity, educational institutions become vulnerable and learners' rights to education are compromised.

Causes of Herder-Farmer Conflict in Nigeria: The following include causes of herders-farmers conflict in Nigeria;

1. **Resource Scarcity:** Herders-farmers conflict in many affected communities in Nigeria is said to be rooted in the consequences of scarce resources amidst increasing demand and environmental stress. While the population of both herders and farmers have continued to grow at geometric rate, resources seem to remain constant. This generates competition for the available resources resulting in excessive pressures and environmental stress. This heightens tension between herders and farmers in host communities of schools, thereby raising threats to their existence.
2. **Competition for Land:** This springs from increasing demand by both herders and farmers. While farmers seek more fertile land for cultivation and growing of their crops, herders also constantly seek more grazing areas and water sources for their increasing livestock. This generates tension and threatens the existence of schools in host farming communities and their population.
3. **Climate Change and Desertification:** Climate change and factors such as desertification and environmental degradation in some parts of Nigeria and its neighbouring countries has reduced available pastoral land and hence forcing the migration of herders and their livestock towards areas where there are grazing resources and water for the livestock. In recent years, more herders have moved their livestock towards the middle belt and the southern region of Nigeria where there are still fresh grazing resources for their livestock. Climate induced migration has heightened encounter between herders and farming communities and this threatens the existence of schools and their learners and members of staff in such communities.
4. **Illegal Immigration Pattern:** As the population growth rate of both herders and their livestock increases and desertification occurs in some North African countries, the tendency is for the herders to migrate illegally into Nigeria and other countries in the south and west, which have improved vegetation. This pattern of migration tends to cause more pressures

and harm than good to the original inhabitants of farming communities and the threats are extended to schools situated within such communities.

5. **Population Growth Rate:** Nigerian Population and that of the world is experiencing a rapid growth at geometric rate. This increases demand for available space and resources and increases pressure on available land resources, prompting encroachment and thereby intensifying disputes over land ownership and usage rights.
6. **Weak Governance Structures and Security Failures on Enforcement of Land-Use Policies:** Ineffective law enforcement, poor conflict resolution mechanism and inadequate security responses often allow minor disputes between herders and farmers in farming communities to escalate into violent confrontations. The threats which spring up from the dispute, escalates to schools located within affected communities.
7. **Proliferation of Small Arms:** The widespread availability of sophisticated small weapons in wrong hands has transformed traditional disputes into deadly armed confrontations. This has a greater impact on community peace-building and conflict resolution.
8. **Belief System/Indoctrination:** Some herdsmen especially the immigrants seem to have been indoctrinated and brainwashed into believing and insisting that no part of the country or the world is exclusively owned and or controlled by any group of original inhabitants and so claim to have equal rights/entitlements to the people's land.
9. **Grazing on Farmers' Crops/Destruction of Farms:** There are many instances where herders allow their herds of cattle to graze on crops right in the farmland thereby making it difficult for the farmer to make harvests at the end of the farming season. This generates arguments between the farmer and the herder and often results to violent clashes escalating to the extent that killings and destruction of properties take place. At times, when the community people become displaced from their community, the herders tend to occupy and graze their livestock on people's crops/farmland and school land.
10. **Weak Security Infrastructure:** Most Nigerian communities lack arear surveillance system, adequately trained security personnel and emergency response mechanism. This makes the people, schools and their personnel more vulnerable.
11. **Socio-Political Tensions, Influence/Instability:** Some top political actors tend to recruit armed men to foment violence. If a particular community with a high voting population tend to be impenetrable, they use hired armed herders to displace the community's voting population as a way to whittle down strong opposition. Politically motivated conflicts often spill over to schools and make them vulnerable to insecurity.
12. **Influence of Drug Abuse:** The misuse or abuse of drugs among people seem to contribute significantly to aggression and criminal behaviours. When this is left unchecked, it grows uncontrollably and makes the communities and schools become more insecure.
13. **Presence of Terrorists; Islamic State of West African Province (ISWAP), (ISIS) and their Killings and Cattle Rustling in the North-East and North-West Forests:** There exist expanse of forests in the North-East and North-West of the country where the indigenous herdsmen originally use to graze their livestock. However, the emergence and spread of

terrorist groups such as the Islamic State of West African Province (ISWAP)/Boko-Haram, ISIS, Lakularawa insurgent group and armed bandits in the forests of these regions, who engage in killing of herders and rustling of their cattle for the terrorists' feeding and source of money for sponsorship of purchase of arms, has driven the herdsman from those forests and forced them to adopt a migration pattern which leads them towards the forests in the Middle-Belt and Southern regions of Nigeria. This new migration pattern has generated more tensions between the herders and farmers in these regions where pastoral activities seem to be strange to the farmers.

14. **Weak Conflict Management Institutions:** Poor peace building bodies and lack of conflict resolution mechanism also contributes to escalating tensions between herders and farmers in farming communities.

Implications of Herder-Farmer Conflict on the Safety of Learners and Staff in Nigerian Schools:

1. **Closure of Schools:** When herders-farmers conflict occurs in communities hosting schools, one of the most immediate effects of the violence is closure of schools. This is because violence generates fear of threat to the safety of lives of learners, teachers and other staff and school facilities. Authorities therefore often approve immediate suspension of educational activities and indefinite closure or shutting down of schools pending when peace and normalcy return.
2. **Disruption of Academic Calendar/Programmes:** When Herders-farmers conflict occurs, it leads to abrupt, momentary or indefinite suspension of academic activities and programmes in schools that are located within the affected community, this results to disruption and delay of academic programmes. Muhammed (2024) observed that conflicts contribute to disruption of academic activities and declining educational participation. It often causes interruption of the annual academic calendars and loss of learning continuity.
3. **Physical Violence and Threat to Safety of Learners and Staff:** Herders-farmers conflict in communities hosting schools, often expose learners, teachers and other members of staff to direct attacks, kidnappings and killings. There have been many reports of mass abduction of learners and teachers from schools in different parts of the country recently. This demonstrates that schools are increasingly targeted during violent clashes. This kind of insecurity increases the rate of threats to safety and wellbeing of learners, teachers and the inhabitants of the host communities of schools. It creates fear among teachers, many of whom abandon rural postings for safer urban areas.
4. **Internal Displacement of People:** Herders-farmers conflict results to displacement of learners, teachers and the populace of the host communities. Many families flee affected communities or zones and seek refuge in Internally Displaced Persons (IDP) Camps or in near-by communities. Displaced learners often experience interrupted education, overcrowded classrooms in IDP camps (where available) or complete exclusion from schooling. While these people desert affected host communities to safer places, their

economic life styles and education is affected. Most teachers tend to relocate from conflict prone areas to safer urban centers thereby contributing to teacher shortages in such affected zones.

5. **Forceful Occupation of Affected Host Communities:** Most affected communities including closed/abandoned school land are often forcefully taken over and occupied by the herders who afterwards, freely graze their herds of cattle on the deserted land and premises. When a community is affected, the school alone cannot stand to operate. It therefore shuts down indefinitely, pending the return of peace and normalcy.
6. **Decline in School Enrolment Rate:** Herders-farmers conflict leads to decline in school enrolment rate. This is because the populace must choose safety of lives first and so parents withdraw their children and even may depart host communities for safer places thereby leaving the schools with less or non-prospective admission seekers. According to Akaa et al (2025). There is significant reduction in primary school enrolment in conflict affected communities in Benue State. Displacement, migration from violent prone areas reduces school enrolment rate. At times, the school may be destroyed completely or shutdown, leading to no enrolment, poor retention and completion of educational programmes.
7. **Rise in Out-of-School Children/Drop Out Rate:** As people in affected host communities desert such communities for safety, some learners who become unable to access education may consequently abandon schooling. This leads to increase in rate of out-of-school children (drop-outs) in Nigeria. Observations show that herders-farmers conflict in school host communities significantly reduce school participation. Children in conflict prone areas are less likely to enroll in school and receive fewer years of education.
8. **Decline in Human Capital Development:** Persistent herders-farmers conflict in host communities of Nigerian schools lead to disruption of educational programmes and progress. These further limits development of adequate skilled manpower for national development springing from reduced educational attainment and completion rates among affected population.
9. **Increased Teacher/Learner Absenteeism:** Tension generated by herders-farmers conflict often leads to a continuous increase in teacher/learner absenteeism. This is because they tend to avoid the volatility and stay away for safety of their lives. Even when schools may choose to remain open, learners and teachers often stay away due to fear of attack. When teachers get discouraged from reporting to work regularly due to fear of attacks, it impacts negatively on instructional quality and curriculum implementation. This increases the negative impact on educational attainment.
10. **Reduced Teacher Motivation:** Persistent herders-farmers conflict tends to undermine the moral and job satisfaction of teachers. Teachers who work under constant threats and tension often experience stress, burnout and reduced productivity.
11. **Violent Rape:** This is one of the most commonly reported crimes all over the world. It is an act of violence rather than sex (Maung, 2021). According to the report of the World Health Organization (2002), rape is any sexual act, unwanted sexual comments or advances or acts

to traffic or otherwise directed against a person's sexuality using coercion. It encompasses acts that range from verbal harassment to forced penetration (WHO, 2012). Individuals especially girls and women in conflict affected communities who fall victims of violent attacks, abductions or displacement are often forced by the attackers to brutally gain carnal knowledge of them without their consent. This results in injuries, health complications including sexually transmitted diseases, unwanted pregnancy, psychological trauma; depression, anxiety, fear, post-traumatic stress disorder and loss of self-esteem.

12. **Rise in Educational Inequality:** Constant herders-farmers conflict in communities hosting Nigerian schools greatly impact on educational equality. As schools and educational activities are suspended in conflict prone zones, school activities remain open and operational in schools located in peaceful communities. This leads to educational inequality among learners in the compared communities.
13. **Emotional/Psychological Trauma/Instability:** Herders/farmers conflict exposes learners and staff in schools to violence. This creates severe emotional and psychological consequences for them. It makes them to experience heightened fear, anxiety, depression, psychological trauma, post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) and loss of concentration among learners, teachers and other members of staff in schools. Psychological distress negatively affects learning outcomes and academic performance. Teachers who are exposed to violence may suffer emotional exhaustion which can reduce teaching effectiveness.
14. **Slow Rate of Educational Development:** Increased herders-farmers conflict in communities hosting Nigerian schools tend to undermine teaching and learning and causes decline in educational quality service delivery, causes poor academic performance and progress, slow and weak educational and national development.
15. **Destruction of School Infrastructure:** Herders-farmers conflict in Nigerian communities hosting in schools' results to destruction of educational facilities and loss of valuable educational infrastructure including school buildings, library equipment, office equipment, laboratory equipment, school furniture and learning materials to vandalism and willful destruction.
16. **High Operational/Reconstruction Costs:** Conflicts in host communities of Nigerian schools causes increase in economic and operational costs. The cost of replacement or reconstruction of damaged school facilities constitutes great loss to the economy. It also causes delay in educational progress.
17. **Food Insecurity:** Herders-farmers conflict often results to food insecurity. This is because, farmers nurse the fear to go to farms due to threat to their personal security. According to Obikaeze et al. (2023), struggles between farmers and herders have generated "human and food security challenges" across Nigerian communities.

Recommended Strategies for Improved Learners, Staff and Nigerian School Safety:

The following strategies are recommended for actions to mitigate herders-farmers conflict and to foster security in Nigerian schools:

1. **Community Based Peace-Building/Conflict Resolution Mechanism:** One of the strategies to ensure an improved school safety is to constitute and strengthen community-based peacebuilding, local peace and conflict resolution bodies involving herders, farmers and traditional leaders. Community leaders can use their influence to mediate disputes and avoid escalation using the traditional conflict resolution mechanisms.
2. **Deployment of Adequate Security Personnel Around Schools:** When adequate security personnel are deployed to vulnerable school communities, it tends to douse the heightened security tension around the schools and their host community environments.
3. **Provision of Security Infrastructure:** Another veritable strategy is the provision of supports in the form of street lighting, communication gadgets, security guards, fencing projects, emergency response system and others to promote school safety.
4. **Collaboration with Security Agencies/Intelligence Gathering:** Effective engagement in security planning and establishing formal forum for information sharing for prompt actions and emergency response to prevent security breakdown in communities and Nigerian schools. Maintaining close relationship between schools and security agencies as well as local vigilante groups and community policing units is a strong tool for improved and secured school environments.
5. **Community-Policing, Community/Neighbourhood-Watch:** Community Policing and vigilance systems can be organized within the community to secure schools using adequate surveillance. Contemporary security frameworks in Nigeria increasingly recognize the need for multi-stakeholder collaboration. The Nigeria Police Force's Schools Protection Squad (SPS) initiative and the Safe Schools Initiative of the Federal Government of Nigeria, for instance, includes community stakeholders in its community-based strategy to safeguard schools. Training and grassroots advocacy are central to building trust with communities and enabling them to participate meaningfully in school security. Obi-Nwosu et al. (2025) Urged that "mutual understanding and trust between security personnel and the people of the community" are essential for effective school protection. Community, police partnership is encouraged, to protect students and school communities. These insights, demonstrate that security cannot be imposed solely by external forces but must be co-constructed through reciprocal engagement.
6. **Psychological Support and Trauma Healing:** Victims of herders-farmers conflict can be mobilized for emotional support by government, communities, religious organizations, counselling organizations etc. They can provide counselling services for learners and members of staff in conflict prone zones. It is a great support for victims/survivors when stakeholders establish mechanisms for detecting and responding to emerging threats.
7. **Community Security Forum:** Stakeholders can organize security meetings involving community leaders, security agents, youth-based groups and religious organizations within the host communities. This will foster collaborative efforts towards school safety.
8. **Sustained Security Education and Awareness Campaigns:** Government and education stakeholders should ensure regular training and awareness campaigns on emergency

response, conflict resolution, drug abuse prevention, and other measures. Sensitization campaigns can help community members understand the importance of their roles in maintaining school safety.

9. **Intensifying the Safe School Initiatives:** Strengthening safety frameworks like the Safe Schools Initiative which has led to the creation of units under the Nigeria Police, Nigeria Security and Civil Defense Corp and the Nigerian Peace Corps, responsible for provision of security for schools with particular emphasis on schools located within conflict prone zones will improve security situation in Nigerian schools and host communities.
10. **Sustainable Resource Management:** Developing and implementing deliberate policies aimed at addressing grazing routes, ranching, land use management and climate adaptation can reduce resource-based competition and conflicts.
11. **Education Support for Displaced Learners:** The provision of continuous access to education for Internally Displaced Persons (IDP) in camps by Government and Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs) helps as a palliative measure to sustain educational growth.

Conclusion

Herders/farmers conflict has emerged as a major security concern in Nigeria recently. It constitutes major threats to the Nigerian education system. Beyond the immediate loss of lives and property, herders-farmers conflict undermines the safety of learners and educational personnel, it disrupts academic infrastructure and contributes to declining educational outcomes, schools in conflict affected communities increasingly operate under conditions of fear and uncertainty. To ensure the safety of learners and members of staff in schools, comprehensive approaches that integrate conflicts resolution must be employed. Peace and improved security support educational progress and sustainable resource management. In the absence of decisive actions, the continued escalation of herders-farmers conflict may further hamper the efforts of the government towards achieving inclusive and quality education for all.

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